ALLAMAHUL BAYAN SERIES · BOOK 70

عَلَّمَهُ الْبَيَانَ

My First Shona Alphabet

Mavara angu ekutanga echiShona

A Coloring Book to Learn, Trace & Say the 23 Shona Letters with English Phonetics

A a B b C c

Written by Hafez Abdullah Muhammad Minhaz Reza

Illustrations: AI-assisted, edited by the author

Maktabatu Kunujul Akhirah

مكتبة كنوز الآخرة

REVIEW DRAFT — not for publication

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My First Shona Alphabet — Mavara angu ekutanga echiShona
Allamahul Bayan Series, Book 70

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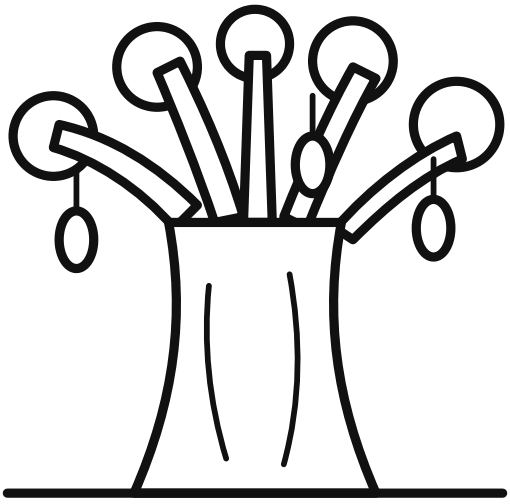
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A note of respect: this book contains verses of the Noble Qur'an (pages 4–5). Please handle it with care and keep it in a clean place.



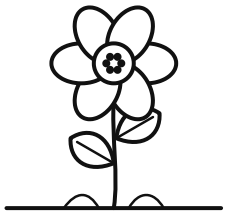
This book belongs to

Muridzi webhuku iri:

I started learning Shona on







ABOUT THIS SERIES

The Allamahul Bayan Series

عَلَّمَهُ الْبَيَانَ

ʿallamahul-bayān — "He taught him clear expression"

الرَّحْمَٰنُ ﴿١﴾ عَلَّمَ الْقُرْآنَ ﴿٢﴾ خَلَقَ الْإِنسَانَ ﴿٣﴾ عَلَّمَهُ الْبَيَانَ ﴿٤﴾

Ar-Raḥmān. ʿAllamal-Qurʾān. Khalaqal-insān. ʿAllamahul-bayān.

"The Most Merciful. He taught the Qur'an. He created the human being. He taught him clear expression (al-bayān)."

Surah Ar-Raḥmān 55:1–4[1]

Surah Ar-Raḥmān — the chapter of *The Most Merciful* — opens by naming some of Allah's greatest gifts to us. First, **He taught the Qur'an**. Then, **He created the human being**. And then, **He taught him al-bayān**.

What does *al-bayān* mean? It comes from an Arabic root that means *to make something clear*. Al-bayān is the gift of speech and understanding: being able to put what is in our hearts and minds into words, to explain, to listen, and to be understood. Animals make sounds, but only people were taught to speak, read and write in languages. Scholars of tafsīr explain that this gift is what lets us learn, teach and pass on guidance — including the Qur'an itself.

So every time a child says a new word, sounds out a letter, or writes their first line in a new language, they are using a gift that Allah Himself says He taught. That is the heart of this series: **learning languages as a way of thanking Allah for al-bayān.**

Languages and colours: two signs of Allah

وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ خَلْقُ السَّمَاوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَاخْتِلَافُ أَلْسِنَتِكُمْ وَأَلْوَانِكُمْ ۚ إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّلْعَالِمِينَ ﴿٢٢﴾

Wa min āyātihī khalqus-samāwāti wal-arḍi wakh-tilāfu alsinatikum wa alwānikum. Inna fī dhālika la-āyātil-lil-ʿālimīn.

"And among His signs is the creation of the heavens and the earth, and the variety of your languages and your colours. Surely in that are signs for those who know."

Surah Ar-Rūm 30:22[1]

In Surah Ar-Rūm, Allah tells us that the **many languages** of people and their **many colours** are among His signs. A coloring book that teaches a language brings both of these signs together in a child's hands: they meet a new language, and they fill its letters with colour.

وَجَعَلْنَاكُمْ شُعُوبًا وَقَبَائِلَ لِتَعَارَفُوا

Wa jaʿalnākum shuʿūban wa qabāʾila li-taʿārafū.

"...and We made you into peoples and tribes so that you may get to know one another."

Surah Al-Ḥujurāt 49:13 (part)[1]

Allah made us into many peoples *so that we may get to know one another*. Learning even a few letters of someone's language is a beautiful first step towards knowing them.

How each book in the series works

Every book introduces one language **through English**:

- where the language is spoken, with a map to color;
- every letter of its alphabet, with its name in the language itself *and* in English letters;
- simple English sound guides, so a parent who has never heard the language can still help;
- a word and picture for every letter, to color, trace and say out loud.

Book 70 is Shona. More languages from around the world are in the series, in shā' Allāh.

FOR PARENTS AND TEACHERS

How to use this book

Begin with **Bismillah**, and go **little and often**: one letter a day is plenty for a young child. For each letter:

1. **Say it.** Read the letter's name and its sound guide together. Say it three times.
2. **Color it.** Color the big letter any way your child likes.
3. **Trace it.** Trace the dotted letters with a pencil, then try one alone in the empty boxes.
4. **Meet the word.** Say the word, color the picture, and talk about it in English.

Marker tip: every coloring page has a blank back, so colours cannot spoil the next activity. Slip a sheet of scrap paper behind the page you are coloring anyway — it keeps the next page clean.

Reading the English sound guides

- **CAPITALS** in the pronunciation show the syllable said a little more strongly: *MVOO-rah*. (Shona is really a tone language: some syllables are said higher, others lower.)
- **Plain b, d** are softer than in English: the air is pulled in a little. **bh, dh** are the ordinary English b and d.
- **sv** and **zv** are "whistled" s and z, said with rounded lips — try *svika* and *zvino*!
- Sounds follow standard Shona as taught in Zimbabwean schools.

Three ways to see every sound

Each letter page shows the sound three ways: the letter's **Shona name** written in Shona (native phonetics), the **same name in English letters**, and an **English sound guide**. The box marked *Shona syllables* shows how the letter is named in class and the row of syllables Shona children chant when they learn to read (ba be bi bo bu), plus any letter team that changes its sound.

The pronunciation guides are simplified for young learners and follow standard Shona (the school language of Zimbabwe).

MEET THE LANGUAGE

Hello, Shona! chiShona

chee-SHOH-nah — the Shona word for the language

Who speaks it?
More than **10 million people** speak Shona at home, and many more use it every day.[3]

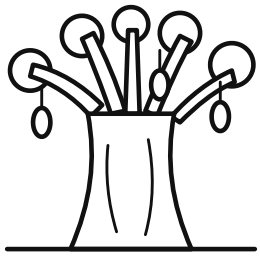
Where?
Mostly in **Zimbabwe**, the land between the Zambezi and Limpopo rivers, and also in parts of **Mozambique**.

How is it written?
In the **Latin alphabet**, from **left to right**, almost exactly as it sounds.

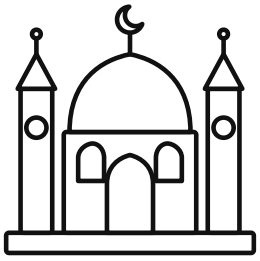
How many letters?
23 letters, plus letter teams such as **ch, sh, sv, zv**.

Whistling words!
Shona has “whistled” sounds, written **sv** and **zv**. Few languages in the world have them.

Did you know?
The name **Zimbabwe** comes from Shona *dzimba dzemabwe*, “houses of stone”, after the great stone walls built there long ago.





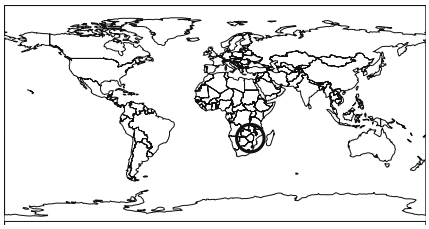


The Shona Alphabet mavara

23 letters — mavara

Aa *ah*	**Bb** *bah*	**Cc** *chah*	**Dd** *dah*	**Ee** *eh*	**Ff** *fah*
Gg *gah*	**Hh** *hah*	**Ii** *ee*	**Jj** *jah*	**Kk** *kah*	**Mm** *mah*
Nn *nah*	**Oo** *oh*	**Pp** *pah*	**Rr** *rah*	**Ss** *sah*	**Tt** *tah*
Uu *oo*	**Vv** *vah*	**Ww** *wah*	**Yy** *yah*	**Zz** *zah*	

Read the alphabet row by row — the same order as in this book.



The circle shows southern Africa on the world map.

COLOR THE MAP

Where is Shona spoken?



Color it: the land **green** · the ocean **blue**. **Find it:** Shona is spoken in Harare, Mutare, Masvingo and Gweru. The dashed line shows where most Shona families live.

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THE LETTERS

The Letters mavara

mah-VAH-rah — “the letters”

Shona is written with **23 letters**: the English alphabet without **L**, **Q** and **X** (they appear only in a few borrowed words). **C** is used only in **CH**.

Read it as you say it
Every Shona letter keeps its sound, so once you know the letters you can read almost any word. Shona children learn to read in **syllables**: *ba be bi bo bu, cha che chi cho chu…*

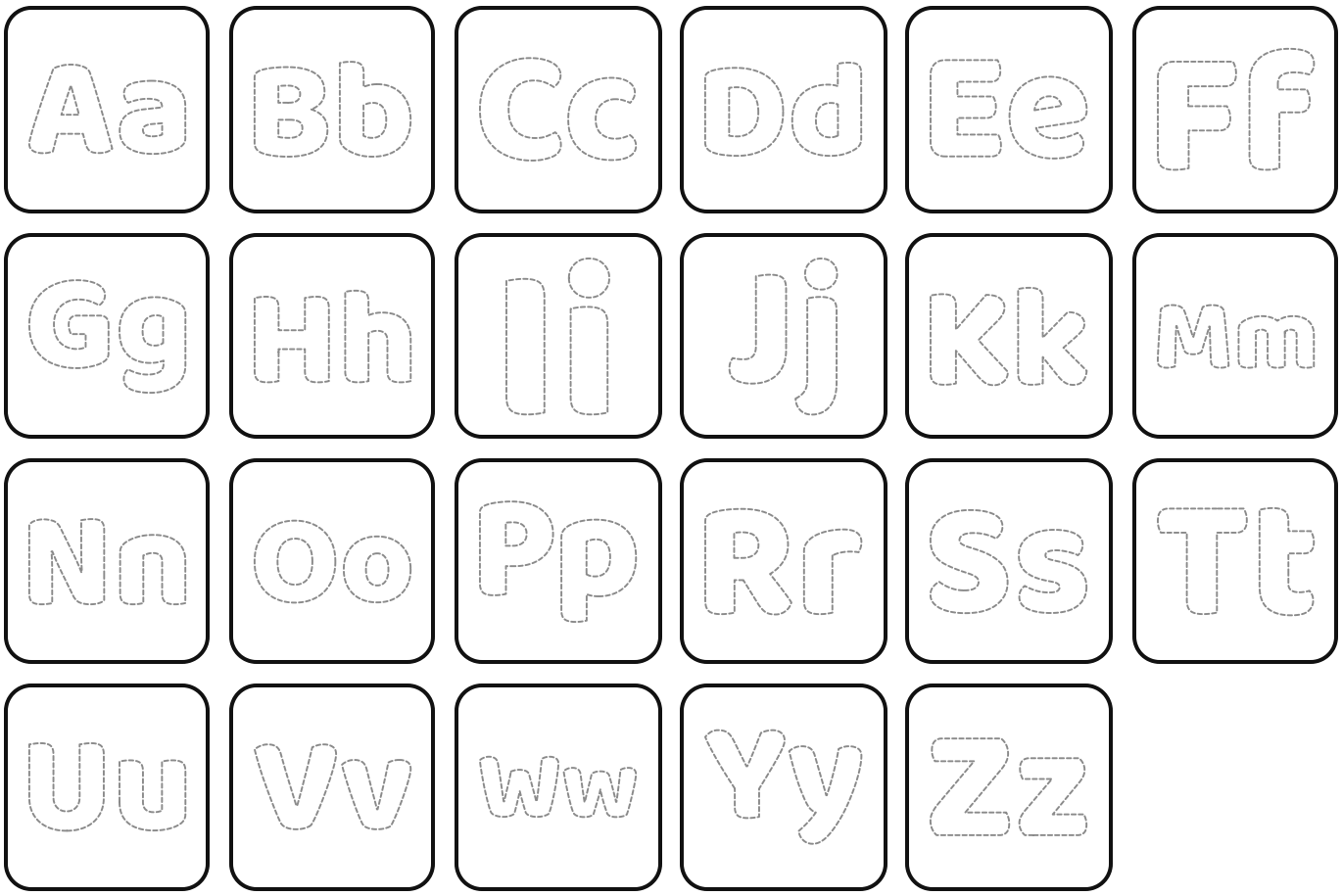
Letters that team up
Some sounds are written with two or three letters together: **bh, ch, dh, mh, nh, ny, sh, sv, ts, vh, zh, zv**… You will meet them on the letter pages.

Big and small
Each page shows the **capital letter** and the **small letter** side by side: **Aa**. Color both!

PENCIL WARM-UP

Trace the letters mavara

Use a **pencil**. Say each letter's name as you trace it.



Aa

NAME · ZITA

a

ah

SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

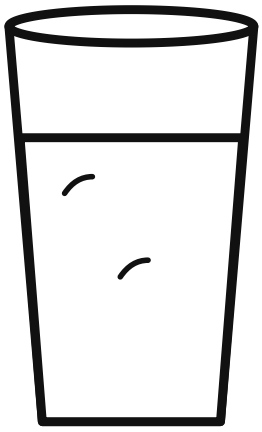
‘a’ as in “father”

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

A a — «a»

ba · ka · ma · na

Few Shona words begin with A, but almost every word ends with a vowel. Hear it at the end of *mvura*!



AA **IS FOR**

mvura

MVOO-rah

water

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Aa Aa Aa Aa

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Bb

NAME · ZITA

ba

bah

SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

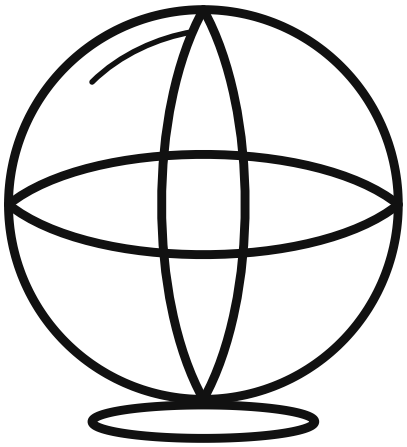
a soft ‘b’, said while swallowing a little; BH is the ‘b’ of “ball”

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

B b — «ba»

ba · be · bi · bo · bu

b = a soft, swallowed b · bh = b as in “ball”



BB IS FOR

bhora

BOH-rah

ball

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Bb Bb Bb Bb

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Cc

NAME · ZITA

cha

chah

SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

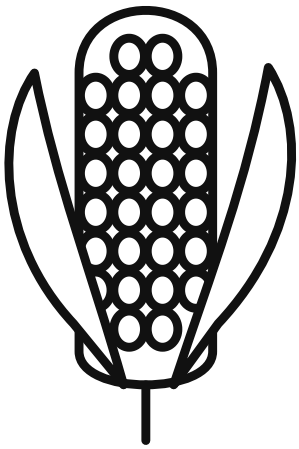
'ch' as in "church" — C is always written CH

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

C c — «cha»

cha · che · chi · cho · chu

In Shona, C never stands alone: it is always CH.



CC IS FOR

chibage

chee-BAH-geh

maize cob (corn)

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Cc Cc Cc Cc

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Dd

NAME · ZITA

da

dah

SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

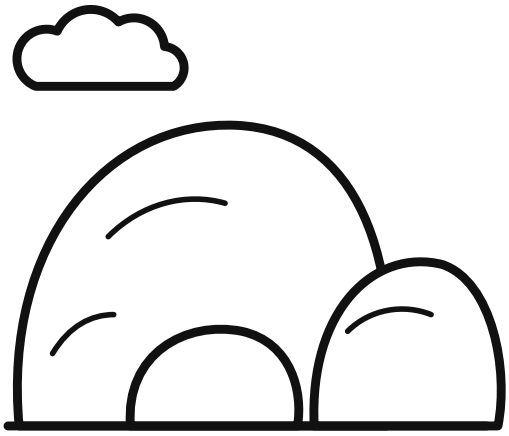
a soft ‘d’, said while swallowing a little; DH is the ‘d’ of “dog”

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

D d — «da»

da · de · di · do · du

d = a soft, swallowed d · dh = d as in “dog” · dz = ‘dz’ as in “adze”



DD IS FOR

dombo

DOHM-boh

rock

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Dd Dd Dd Dd

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Ee

NAME · ZITA

e

eh

SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

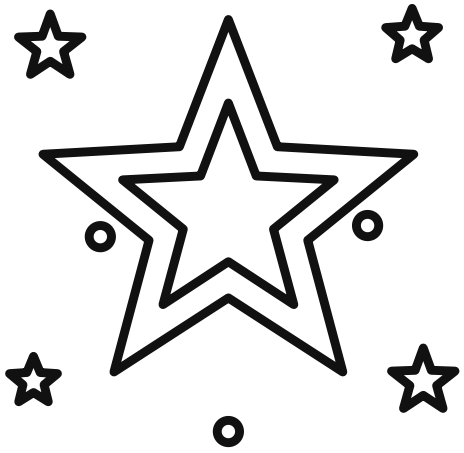
‘e’ as in “bed”

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

E e — «e»

be · ke · me · ne

Few words begin with E. Can you find it inside *nyeredzi*?



EE IS FOR

nyeredzi

nyeh-REH-dzee

star

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Ee Ee Ee Ee

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Ff

NAME · ZITA

fa

fah

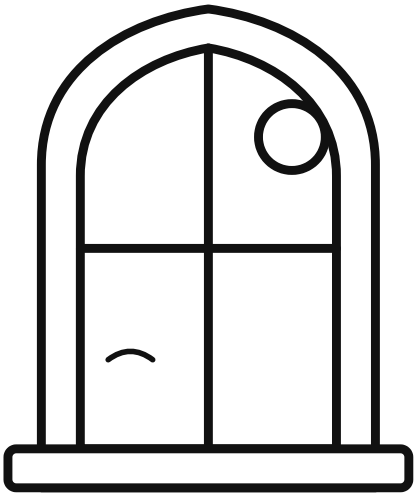
SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

‘f’ as in “fan”

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

F f — «fa»

fa · fe · fi · fo · fu



FF IS FOR

fasitera

fah-see-TEH-rah

window

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Ff Ff Ff Ff

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Gg

NAME · ZITA

ga

gah

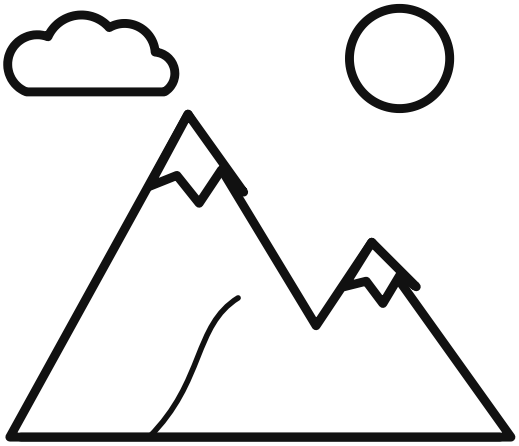
SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

‘g’ as in “go”

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

G g — «ga»

ga · ge · gi · go · gu



GG IS FOR

gomo

GOH-moh

mountain

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Gg Gg Gg Gg

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Hh

NAME · ZITA

ha

hah

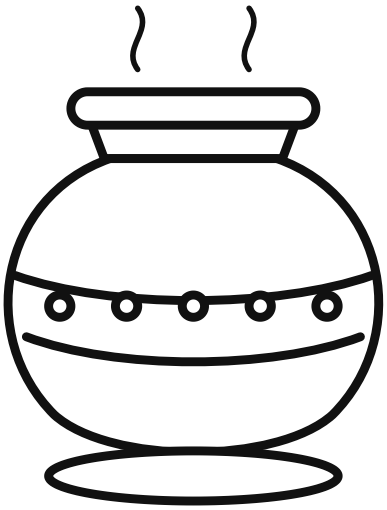
SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

a soft, breathy ‘h’ as in “hat”

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

H h — «ha»

ha · he · hi · ho · hu



HH IS FOR

hari

HAH-ree

clay pot

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Hh Hh Hh Hh

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NAME · ZITA

i

ee

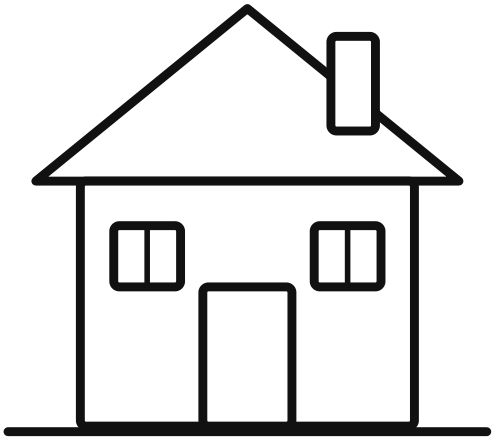
SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

‘ee’ as in “see”

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

| i — «i»

bi · ki · mi · ni



II IS FOR

imba

EEM-bah

house

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

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Jj

NAME · ZITA

ja

jah

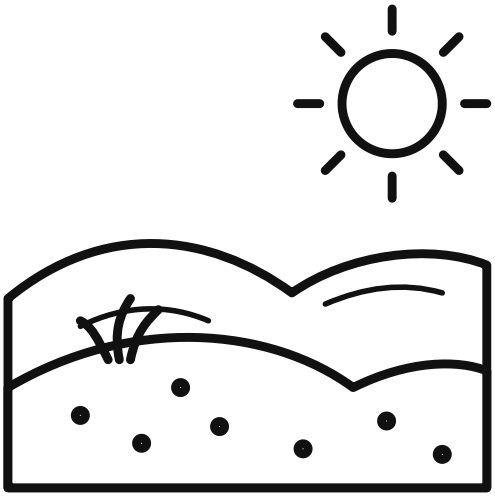
SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

'j' as in "jam"

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

J j — «ja»

ja · je · ji · jo · ju



JJ IS FOR

jecha

JEH-chah

sand

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Jj Jj Jj Jj

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Kk

NAME · ZITA

ka

kah

SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

‘k’ as in “sky” (no puff of air)

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

K k — «ka»

ka · ke · ki · ko · ku



KK IS FOR

kapu

KAH-poo

cup

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Kk Kk Kk Kk

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Mm

NAME · ZITA

ma

mah

SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

‘m’ as in “moon”

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

M m — «ma»

ma · me · mi · mo · mu

mh = a breathy ‘m’ · mw = ‘mw’ said together



MM IS FOR

mwedzi

MWEH-dzee

moon

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Mm Mm Mm Mm

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Nn

NAME · ZITA

na

nah

SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

‘n’ as in “net”

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

N n — «na»

na · ne · ni · no · nu

nh = a breathy ‘n’ · ny = ‘ny’ as in “canyon” · n' = ‘ng’ as in “sing”



NN IS FOR

nhanga

NHAHN-gah

pumpkin

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Nn Nn Nn Nn

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Oo

NAME · ZITA

o

oh

SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

‘o’ as in “for” — short and pure

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

O o — «o»

bo · ko · mo · no

Few words begin with O. Can you find it inside *moto*?



OO IS FOR

moto

MOH-toh

fire

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Oo Oo Oo Oo

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Pp

NAME · ZITA

pa

pah

SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

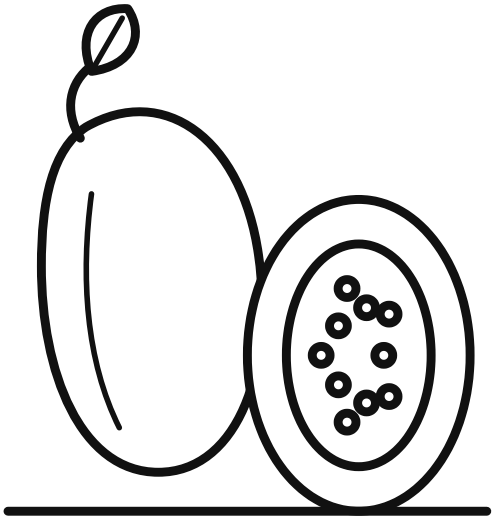
‘p’ as in “spin” (no puff of air)

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

P p — «pa»

pa · pe · pi · po · pu

pf = ‘pf’ said together, as in “cupful”



PP IS FOR

popo

POH-poh

pawpaw (papaya)

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Pp Pp Pp Pp

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Rr

NAME · ZITA

ra

rah

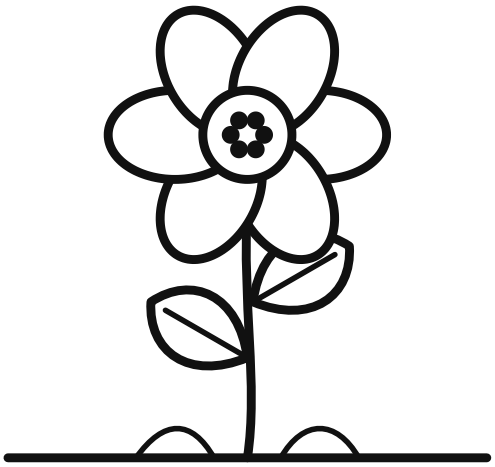
SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

a light, tapped ‘r’ — almost an ‘l’

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

R r — «ra»

ra · re · ri · ro · ru



RR IS FOR

ruva

ROO-vah

flower

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Rr Rr Rr Rr

This page is left blank on purpose, so your colours don’t bleed through. ✿

Ss

NAME · ZITA

sa

sah

SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

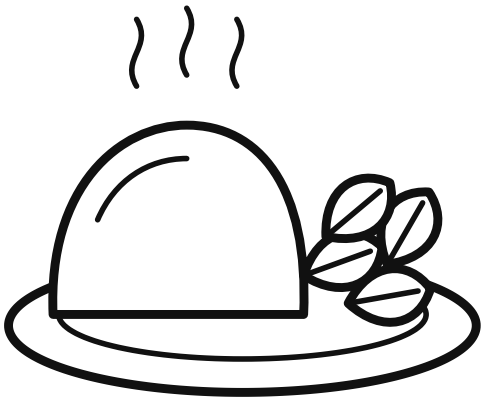
‘s’ as in “sun”

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

S s — «sa»

sa · se · si · so · su

sh = ‘sh’ as in “shoe” · sv = a whistled ‘s’ — a Shona sound!



SS IS FOR

sadza

SAH-dzah

sadza — thick maize porridge

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Ss Ss Ss Ss

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Tt

NAME · ZITA

ta

tah

SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

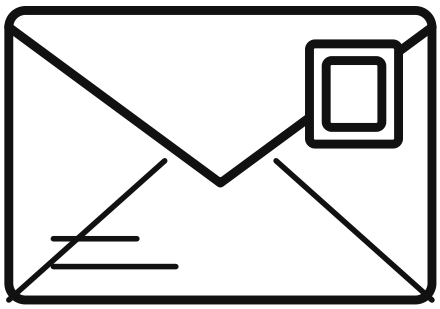
‘t’ as in “stop” (no puff of air)

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

T t — «ta»

ta · te · ti · to · tu

ts = ‘ts’ as in “cats”



TT IS FOR

tsamba

TSAHM-bah

letter (to post)

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Tt Tt Tt Tt

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Uu

NAME · ZITA

u

oo

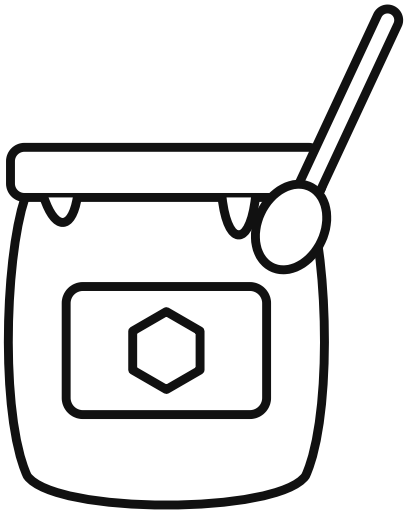
SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

‘oo’ as in “moon”

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

U u — «u»

bu · ku · mu · nu



UU IS FOR

uchi

OO-chee

honey

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Uu Uu Uu Uu

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Vv

NAME · ZITA

va

vah

SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

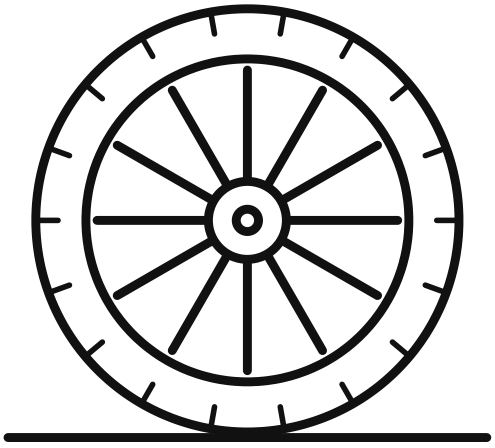
a soft ‘v’ made with both lips;
VH is the ‘v’ of “van”

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

V v — «va»

va · ve · vi · vo · vu

v = a soft v with both lips · vh = v as in “van”



VV IS FOR

vhiri

VEE-ree

wheel

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Vv Vv Vv Vv

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Ww

NAME · ZITA

wa

wah

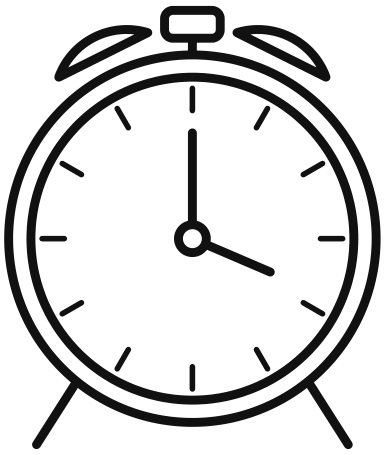
SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

‘w’ as in “water”

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

W w — «wa»

wa · we · wi · wo · wu



WW **IS FOR**

wachi

WAH-chee

watch, clock

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Ww Ww Ww Ww

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Yy

NAME · ZITA

ya

yah

SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

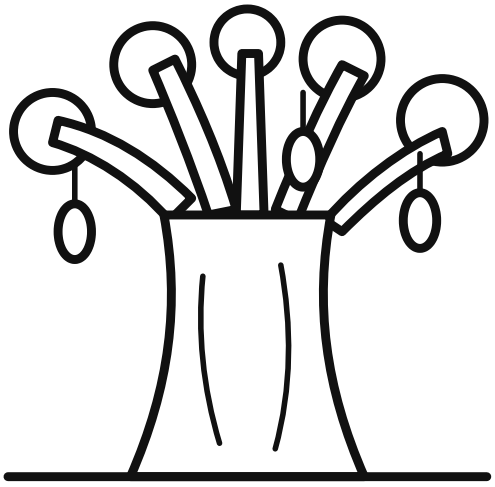
‘y’ as in “yes”

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

Y y — «ya»

ya · ye · yi · yo · yu

Few words begin with Y. Can you find it inside *muuyu*?



YY IS FOR

muuyu

moo-OO-yoo

baobab tree

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

Yy Yy Yy Yy

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Zz

NAME · ZITA

za

zah

SAY IT · ENGLISH SOUND GUIDE

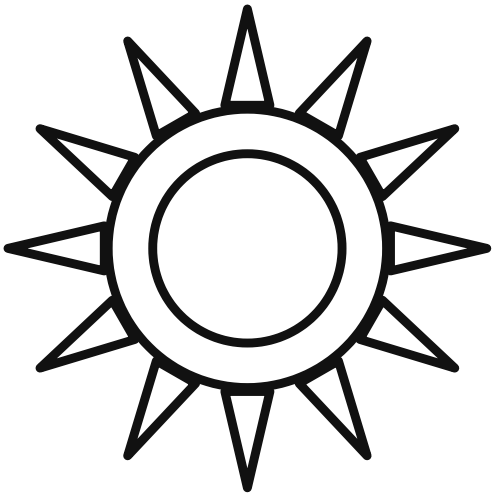
‘z’ as in “zoo”

SHONA SYLLABLES · BA BE BI BO BU

Z z — «za»

za · ze · zi · zo · zu

zh = ‘s’ as in “measure” · zv = a whistled ‘z’ — a Shona sound!



ZZ IS FOR

zuva

ZOO-vah

sun

Color the picture and say the word three times!

TRACE IT WITH A PENCIL, THEN WRITE IT ON YOUR OWN · NYORA

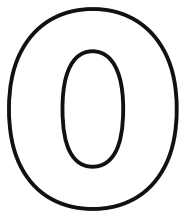
Zz Zz Zz Zz

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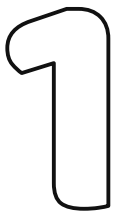
BONUS

Shona numbers nhamba *(NHAHM-bah)*

Color the numbers and count out loud in Shona: *ZEE-roh, POH-shee, PEE-ree, TAH-too...*



0
ziro
ZEE-roh
zero



1
poshi
POH-shee
one



2
piri
PEE-ree
two



3
tatu
TAH-too
three



4
ina
EE-nah
four



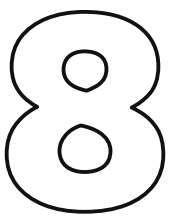
5
shanu
SHAH-noo
five



6
tanhatu
tah-NHAH-too
six



7
nomwe
NOH-mweh
seven



8
sere
SEH-reh
eight



9
pfumbamwe
pfoom-BAH-mweh
nine

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LET'S TALK

My first Shona words Mazwi ekutanga

Now that you know the letters, try saying these with your family.

Assalaamu alaikum
as-sah-LAH-moo ah-LAY-koom
Peace be upon you (the Muslim greeting)

Wa alaikum assalaam
wah ah-LAY-koom as-sah-LAHM
And upon you be peace (the reply)

Mhoroi!
mhoh-ROH-ee
Hello! (polite)

Zita rangu ndi ...
ZEE-tah RAHN-goo ndee ...
My name is ...

Ndatenda
ndah-TEHN-dah
Thank you

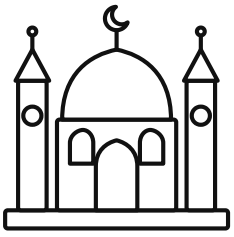
Jazakallahu khairan
jah-zah-KAH-lah-hoo KHAI-rahn
May Allah reward you with good

amai · baba
ah-MAH-ee · BAH-bah
Mother · Father

mukoma · munin'ina
moo-KOH-mah · moo-NEE-ngee-nah
Big brother or sister · Little brother or sister

hongu · kwete
HOHN-goo · KWEH-teh
Yes · No

Ndiri kudzidza chiShona!
ndee-ree koo-DZEE-dzah chee-SHOH-nah
I am learning Shona!







REFERENCES & SOURCES

Where our facts come from

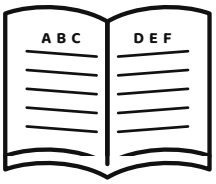
[1] **The Noble Qur'an** — Surah Ar-Raḥmān 55:1–4, Surah Ar-Rūm 30:22 and Surah Al-Ḥujurāt 49:13. Arabic text and meanings checked against **Quran.com**; the English meanings in this book are simplified for children.

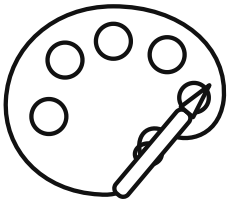
[2] **Map** — outlines from **Natural Earth** (public domain), via the *world-atlas* data set.

[3] **Language facts** — speaker numbers from **Ethnologue** (SIL International), rounded.

What's next?
You have met all **23 Shona letters**! Keep practising by reading signs, books and food packets written in Shona, and look out for the other books in the **Allamahul Bayan Series**, in shā' Allāh.

Enjoyed this book?
A short review on Amazon helps other families find it — *jazākumullāhu khayran!*







Certificate of Achievement

Mashallah! Waita zvakanaka!

MAH-shah-lah! wah-EE-tah zvah-kah-NAH-kah! — Well done, you did it well!

This certifies that

_____

has learned, traced and colored
all 23 letters of the Shona alphabet.

_____ Date

_____ Grown-up's signature

Minhaz Reza
Hafez Abdullah Muhammad Minhaz Reza, author

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